ଓଡ଼ିଶା ରାଜ୍ୟ ମୁକ୍ତ ବିଶ୍ୱବିଦ୍ୟାଳୟ, ସମ୍ବଲପୁର, ଓଡ଼ିଶା

Odisha State Open University, Sambalpur, Odisha

Established by an Act of Government of Odisha.

ASSIGNMENT

Enrollment Number	**MAHD2420173**
Name	**JAGABANDHU PRADHAN**
Admission Session	**February 2025**
Programme	**Master of Arts (Hindi) (MAHD)**
Assignment Number	02
Course Code	PGV - IKS - 206
Course Title	INDIAN KNOWLEDGE SYSTEM
Study Centre	Narasingh Choudhury (Auto) College, Jajpur
Date of Submission	11/03/2026

ओड़ीशा राज्य मुक्त विश्वविद्यालय, सबलपुर
हिंदी विभाग
स्नातकोत्तर हिंदी
प्रश्न - पत्र
सेमेस्टर - 02
पाठ्यक्रम नाम - INDIAN KNOWLEDGE SYSTEM
सत्रीय कार्य - 02
पाठ्यक्रम कोड - PGV-IKS-206
पाठ्यक्रम क्षेत्र - इकाई 01 से 08 तक।

No-3 The kitchen of the Jagannath Temple is regarded as one of the largest in the world and follows traditional cooking methods using earthen pots stacked vertically over wood-fired stoves. How does this case illustrate the integration of scientific knowledge, ecology and community life in odisha's knowledge system?

Interduction

The kitchen of the Jagannath Temple is considered one of the largest temple kitchens in the world. Every day thousands of devotees are served sacred food known as Mahaprasad. The cooking process follows

traditional methods that have been practiced for centuries. Earthen pots are stacked vertically on wood-fired stoves, and the food is prepared by trained temple cooks following strict rules and rituals. This system beautifully demonstrates the integration of scientific knowledge, ecological awareness, and community life within odisha's traditional knowledge systems.

Historical Background

The Jagannath Temple in puri has been a major religious and cultural center for many centuries. The temple kitchen was developed to prepare food offerings for Lord Jagannath and to distribute them among devotees. over time a highly organized cooking system evoled. The cooking responsibility is carried out by temple cooking known as Suaras and Mahasuaras, who inherit this traditional knowledge from their ancestors. The kitchen contains hundreds of clay stoves and thousands of earthen pots that are used daily to prepare large quantities of food

Traditional Cooking Method

One of the most unique features of the Jagannath Temple kitchen is the vertical stacking of earthenpots. Usually five to seven pots are placed one above another on a single stove. Fire wood burns at the bottom, and heat rises upward through the stacked pots.

Interestingly, in many cases the pot placed at the top cooks faster than the ones below. This happens because the heat and steam generated from the fire move upward and circulate through the pots. The trapped steam cooks the food effectively and allows several dishes to be prepared at the same time. This method saves fuel and increases cooking efficiency.

The food is cooked in earthen clay pots, which distribute heat evenly and maintain the natural flavor of the food. Clay pots also retain moisture and help preserve nutrients. This traditional method shows that ancient cooks had a deep practical understanding of cooking science.

Scientific Aspects

Although the Jagannath Temple kitchen is based on religious traditions, many of its practices have scientific explanations.

First, the vertical arrangement of pots reflects the principle of heat convection where hot air and steam move upward. This natural movement of heat allows multiple layers of food to cook simultaneously.

Second, earthen pots are known for their excellent heat distribution. Clay heats slowly but evenly which prevents food from burning and improves the quality of cooking. Modern researchers recognize that clay cooking. Modern researchers recognize that clay cook ware is healthier and more environmentally friendly than many metal or synthetic materials.

Third, the temple kitchen maintains strict rules of cleanliness and discipline. Only authorize cooks can enter the cooking area, and they follow specific hygienic practices.

these traditions indirectly maintain food safety and quality.

Ecological and Environmental Significance

The Jagannath Temple kitchen also reflects ecological wisdom. The use of natural materials such as clay pots and firewood represents a sustainable system that has minimal environmental impact.

Clay pots are biodegradable and can easily return to the soil after use. Unlike modern plastic or synthetic utensils, they do not create harmful waste. The cooking system also uses local agricultural products such as rice ~~used local agricultural~~ or vegetables, and lentils grown in nearby regions. This supports local farmers and reduces the environmental cost of transportation.

Community and Social Life

Another important aspect of the Jagannath Temple kitchen is its role in community life. Every day thousands of devotees gather to receive mahaprasad. People from different

castes, social groups, and economic background sit together and share the same food.

This tradition promotes the idea of equality and unity. In the temple context, Mahaprasad is considered sacred, and everyone has the right to receive it. This practice reflects the inclusive philosophy associated with Lord Jagannath.

The Kitchen also provides employment and livelihood to many families connected with temple service. Generations of cooks, helpers, and workers continue to serve the temple and preserve its traditions. Their skills ~~represe~~ represent a valuable part of Odisha's cultural heritage.

Integration of Knowledge Systems

The Jagannath Temple Kitchen clearly shows how traditional Indian knowledge systems combine practical experience, environmental awareness and social values. What appears to be a religious activity also contains elements of science, ecology, and community organization.

The efficient cooking methods demonstrate knowledge of heat and steam management. The use of natural materials reflects ecological responsibility. The distribution of Mahaprasad strengthens social unity and cultural identity.

Conclusion

In conclusion the kitchen of the Jagannath Temple in puri is not only a place where food is prepared for religious offerings but also a remarkable example of traditional knowledge in practice. Its cooking techniques, ecological awareness, and social functions show how ancient systems integrated science, environment, and community life. Studying such traditions helps us appreciate the wisdom of Indian knowledge systems and their relevance even in the modern world.